

Uji: Being-Time

1. The phrase

In Uji, Dogen writes of 'being-time.' The hyphen in English is interpretive: it signals that being and time should not be treated as two independently given categories, with beings merely located inside an external container called time. Each being is temporal through and through; each time is the time of concrete beings and activities.

2. Against the container model

Ordinary speech encourages a picture: first there is time, then events occupy positions in it. Dogen's examples - mountains, oceans, everyday activities - pressure that picture. If there is no eventless standpoint outside all events from which time is observed, the container can be a conceptual abstraction mistaken for a metaphysical thing.

3. Passage

Dogen can say that the sixteen-foot golden Buddha is time and that everyday standing and sitting are time. This does not merely mean 'everything exists at some time,' which is trivial. The stronger reading says the mode of existence of a thing is inseparable from its temporal articulation. Time is not an attribute added afterward.

4. Flow and non-flow

Dogen uses language of passage or 'flowing' while also insisting that each moment fully abides in its own position. These claims look contradictory only if flow requires moments to lose their identity into a single external stream. A network model is possible: moments are related, each fully itself, with movement articulated through their relations rather than through a substance called Time.

5. Agency

Being-time also changes how agency is pictured. If the self is a fixed entity carried through moments, action belongs to that enduring owner. If self is temporal activity, agency is enacted in each concrete occasion. This does not eliminate responsibility; it relocates it from metaphysical possession to patterns of action, relation, and continuity.

6. Relation to practice-realization

Practice-realization only occurs now, but 'now' should not become a razor-thin present opposed to past and future. Dogen's temporal thought allows past training, inherited forms, present enactment, and future consequences to be present as relations within an activity. 'Just this moment' is not historical amnesia.

7. Two interpretations

A: mystical eternal present - time disappears in pure awareness. B: radical temporality - every being is a temporal event, so there is no need to escape time. B fits the title and many examples better. A may describe some experiences, but it risks importing a modern perennialist model into a text that is making a different claim.

8. Methodological warning

Dogen is frequently enlisted into Western philosophical systems. Comparison can illuminate, but first establish an interpretation from his vocabulary, genre, sources, and broader corpus. Similarity to Heidegger, phenomenology, or process thought is a second-stage question, not the premise of reading.

9. Question

If every being is being-time, what becomes of impermanence? It is no longer an accidental fact that stable things unfortunately undergo change. Temporality belongs to what things are. The Buddhist problem is then not how to secure a timeless self but how grasping misreads temporal events as possessable substances.

The case

Dōgen says, in effect, that beings are time and that time is not merely something that passes over beings from outside. Take a mountain: on the ordinary container model, the mountain exists while an independent time coordinate changes. On a stronger being-time reading, the mountain's being is inseparable from its temporal actualization. The claim is obscure enough that multiple views deserve reconstruction before evaluation.

Different views

- 1 Container view: beings occupy time as objects occupy space. Problem: it makes Dōgen's identity language needlessly extravagant.
- 2 Moment view: each being is exhausted by a self-contained present. Problem: this can make continuity and memory unintelligible.
- 3 Activity view: a being is its temporally unfolding activity rather than a substance plus temporal location. Problem: the word 'is' may still be doing too much work.
- 4 Network view: each being-time includes relations to other times without collapsing into them. Problem: the account must explain how inclusion differs from a metaphor for causal dependence.

The story continues

Dōgen's examples range freely across standing peaks, oceans, Buddhas, demons, and ordinary activities. That range matters. If being-time applied only to meditation, it would name a special contemplative experience. Instead the text appears to make an ontological claim whose practice consequence is that no present activity is merely waiting outside reality for a privileged moment to arrive. Yet he also speaks of passage and of times not obstructing one another. The theory therefore cannot be a frozen eternal present. It needs both differentiation and interpenetration.

Passage

A useful distinction is between passing away and passage. Passing away suggests that a thing loses its being as time carries it off. Passage can instead name the dynamic articulation by which this time is fully this time and nevertheless related to before and after. Dōgen's language of 'flowing' and 'not flowing' is intelligible if it targets the assumption that relation requires a single external timeline in which moments are interchangeable positions.

A duplication thought experiment

Imagine two practitioners performing visually identical bows at the same clock time. One bow is an impatient means to get to the 'real' meditation; the other is complete as the activity being enacted. If being-time is taken seriously, the difference cannot be represented only by where each bow lies on a temporal axis. The bow's temporal structure includes its orientation toward past, future, self, and task. This thought experiment does not prove Dōgen's ontology, but it shows why practice can motivate a richer conception of temporal activity.

Open Zen Course

<https://ocw.mit.edu/courses/24-00-problems-of-philosophy-fall-2019/>

ZEN.00 Zen: Texts, Practices, Institutions

Open edition

Adapted from MIT OpenCourseWare 24.00 Problems of Philosophy, Fall 2019,
Prof. Miriam Schoenfield. Licensed CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

This independent adaptation is not affiliated with or endorsed by MIT.

<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-sa/4.0/>